Love First, Teach Second

By Joan Clayton

"You're going to have Mary in your room?" a fellow teacher asked. Her voice conveyed apprehension, as she added, "I feel sorry for you."

"She's on medication, you know," another teacher warned. "You will be, too, before the year's over!"

I'd heard similar comments during my eighteen years of teaching, but usually these first-grade children turned out to be normal in every respect.

So I began the year with calm assurance that I could handle whatever came.

Was I in for a surprise!

INTRODUCTION

Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) is one of the most common behavioral disorders among children. Between 3 and 5 percent of all children, as many as 2 million, may suffer from this condition. The most common recommendations for teachers in dealing with ADHD students is to establish control: be consistent, follow definite rules, discipline offenses immediately, offer explanations for what rule was violated and be willing to listen to their side of the story and to reward success: use stickers, post points on a chart, shake hands, smile, use verbal praise. In Love First, Teach Second by Joan Clayton, this veteran teacher has seen it all and tried it all, but nothing is effective her struggling first grader, Mary. Then she has an idea, and amazing and wonderful idea. Love First, Teach Second by Joan Clayton

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A few days before school started, Mary and her mother dropped by to "get acquainted." Golden blonde hair fixed to perfection cascaded down the little girl's back. Large, beautiful blue eyes gazed into mine. Between the outbursts from Mary, which frequently interrupted the conversation between her mother and me, I learned that Mary needed medication for both hyperactivity and asthma. She would need to take one pill after lunch.

Her mother agreed that the office would keep the medicine, and I would send her for it every day after lunch. Mary's mother graciously volunteered as room mother. I was delighted.

Then came the first day of school.

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Mary made her bouncy entrance and dropped purses, tablets, marking pens, hair barrettes and gimmicks of all kinds. Every time I turned around, it seemed that some child was crawling under a table to retrieve Mary's loot.

Whispering seemed impossible to Mary. She frequently blurted out her thoughts. "The answer is ahhhh. . . one. No two . . . No, threeeeeee!"

I knew the scene by heart. She scrubbed vigorously with her eraser, usually tearing the paper, then started the whole procedure with a fresh sheet of paper, again and again.

One day, completely exasperated, I voiced my complaints to the office secretary.

"Mary's medication doesn't seem to help at all."

"What medication?" the secretary questioned. "She hasn't been in for it since school started."

"I send her for her pill every day after lunch." I protested, "and she comes back assuring me that she has taken it."

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After that, I began sending a child I could depend on with her to see that she took her pill. Even with resumption of her daily medication, I still had to deal with Mary's repeated outbursts.

One day, after constant shushing, isolating and reprimanding, I stopped the class and said, "All right, Mary, come to the front. Take all the time you need to talk, wiggle or whatever, so you can settle down and we can get back to work."

Always before, this drastic method had worked. The student, embarrassed, would stand silently and be more than happy to sit down and resume working.

But not Mary. At first she jumped up and down, growling like a caged bear. Then she pounded on the desks with her fists, screaming like Tarzan in the jungle. The children loved the show as Mary alternated between growling, screaming and laughing. This encouraged her to show off even more. After five minutes of these antics, I could stand no more. This little girl had outsmarted the teacher!

In the weeks that followed, I gave rewards,

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praise and reinforcement of positive behavior, when I could find any. Nothing seemed to work.

At the end of one particularly harassing day, I dismissed the children and slumped in the chair behind my desk, totally defeated. I had tried everything.

Everything, that is, except prayer!

With my head on my desk, I prayed, "Lord, help me with this child. Show me the key. Where have I missed it?"

In utter exhaustion, I dozed off. When I awakened a few minutes later, my frustration and weariness had disappeared. Two words kept coming to my mind: "Love her."

I was well aware that those who are the hardest to love are often the ones who need it the most. But I thought I had worked through this, and that I already loved her.

Yet, those two words, "love her," lingered in my mind. And they were there when I awakened the next morning.

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"Lord," I prayed, "I already love her, so I'm going to take those to words to mean that I'm to love her . . . with hugs."

I hurried to school that morning, bursting with anticipation. God had answered, and I was eager to see God's plan unfold. When the bell rang, Mary bounded in with enough energy for the whole class. I gave her paper to write her spelling words on, and she jumped ten frog jumps to her seat.

Then she began to write and spell out loud, "D-o-w-n. Ddddd ooooo wwww nnnnnnn!"

"Mary, come to my desk, please," I said quietly.

With tow hops, a skip, a side two-step and three giant steps backward, Mary obeyed my command.

Silently, I pulled her toward me and held her close. In my thoughts, I was praying, "Lord, help this little child to calm down. Take away whatever is causing her hyperactivity." I continued this tactic. Sometimes these sessions lasted five minutes with no one saying a word. It was just Mary and I holding each other. It was just Mary and I holding each other. The other children

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watched silently and seemed to understand. If Mary's behavior got out of control, we stopped and hugged, just Mary and I, while the class waited patiently and lovingly. There were times we did this four or five times a day.

One week later, Mary's reading teacher came running across the hall. "Whatever has happened to Mary? She isn't the same child!"

"It's called prayer and hug therapy," I explained. "I silently pray for her every day, and before I let her come to the reading class, I stop the children, hug her and say a silent prayer."

"Well, don't ever stop!" the teacher exclaimed.

In just a few short weeks, Mary's behavioral change was noticed by other staff members, too.

I knew in my heart that God was leading.

It is now spring. Last fall seems long ago. Now it's hard to think of Mary as ever having had problems. She acts perfectly normal in every way. When she raises her hand to answer a question, but instead says, "Teacher, I love you," I say a silent prayer of thanksgiving.

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In a few minutes the bell will ring, and the children will come in – each with different needs. As I pass out their papers, I will pray silently for these little lives that have blessed mine so abundantly.

"Lord, bless this child today. Help me always to love first ad teach second."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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